

AI ETHICS LEARNING TOOLKIT

Is AI A Spy?

Exploring Privacy and Surveillance

“Generative AI completely obliterates the idea of individual responsibility for privacy because you can’t control these algorithms’ access to your information, or what they do with it.”

– Dr. Alice Marwick, media scholar

Sam Altman, CEO of OpenAI, recently tweeted that ChatGPT’s improved memory meant that it can now reference past conversations and “get to know you over your life.” Is this helpful, or creepy? **AI privacy** involves how your personal information is collected, used, and shared by AI companies. This includes data scraped from the web without your consent *and* data you input into AI systems through prompts. A 2023 Pew Research poll found that 81% of Americans who had heard of AI believe the information collected by AI companies will be used in ways people are uncomfortable with or that weren’t originally intended. Pew Research also found that 6 in 10 Americans frequently skip reading privacy policies. This

highlights the “privacy paradox,” the gulf between people’s attitudes towards protecting their privacy and their actual online behavior. Despite privacy concerns, many people freely give away their personal data for the convenience of using apps, websites, and now AI tools. For students, AI privacy is particularly significant. As students rely on AI tools for learning, research, writing, and even personal advice, they should be mindful of the sensitive data they share and consider when it’s appropriate to disclose information.

Learning Activities



Conversation Starters A Few Questions to Get the Discussion Going

- What privacy protections do you use to safeguard your identity online? Do you use caution with the information you enter into AI tools? Do you read privacy policies?
- Would you ever talk to an AI chatbot as a friend or confidant? How do the responses make you feel? If you use AI in this way, how is what you share different (or the same) to what you’d share with a friend?
- Can you think of situations where it might be harmful for AI companies to collect, train on, or share someone’s private information? Are there times where AI personalization features are actually helpful?
- Who should be responsible for protecting a user’s privacy in an AI system? Should it be the individual, the AI company, or the government?
- What ethical considerations should guide the use of generative AI in collecting or analyzing sensitive data, such as private

conversations or biometric information?

Active Learning with AI Fun Ways to Explore AI's Strengths and Limitations

- What does AI know about you? Have students prompt AI to see if it “knows” anything about them. If nothing turns up/or your name is too common, what does it have to say about your professor? Did it make anything up? Is it creepy? Where is it sourcing the information?
- AI privacy policy review. Have students work in teams to review the privacy policy for major AI companies ([OpenAI](#), [Google's Gemini](#), [Meta](#)). Ask questions like, what surprised you? What do you find confusing?
- **No AI Alternative:** [Data, Privacy, and Identity card game](#). Try this activity that aims to teach students about the intersections of data, privacy, and identity. A simpler, online version of this activity can be found [here](#).

Disciplinary Extensions Ideas for Exploring AI's Impact in Specific Fields

- **Biology/Ethics:** Students could explore common biometric data collection methods (e.g. fingerprint, facial recognition, DNA sequencing) used in biology and medicine. Ask students to reflect on the ethical implications of different forms of biometric data collection.
- **Social Sciences:** Students could explore how privacy breaches

harm marginalized populations disproportionately. Assign teams different groups of people and have them consider a case study (ex. AI in policing, AI in healthcare, AI in immigration).

- **Philosophy:** Where is the line between a right to privacy and surveillance for security's sake?
- **Computer Science/Engineering:** What are some techniques/mechanisms that can be incorporated into AI tools to provide more privacy for the end user?

Resources

- Bogost, I., & Warzel, C. (2025, April 27). [American panopticon](#). *The Atlantic*. [Magazine article]  
- Burgess, M. (2024, October 12). [How to stop your data from being used to train AI](#). *Wired*. [Magazine article]  
- Joseph, J. (2025, April 11). [ChatGPT has receipts, will now remember everything you've ever told it](#). *PCMag*. [Magazine article] 
- Marwick, A. (2023). [You are not responsible for your own online Privacy](#). *Wired*. [Magazine article]  
- Roose, K., et al. (2021, August 20). [Why Apple is about to search your files](#). *The New York Times*. [Podcast]  Predates GAI but excellent story on privacy & ethics.

Scholarly

- Crowley, J. (2016, November 28). [Identity, privacy & privilege: Using data to discuss systemic racism – Ethical Tech](#). [Blog post] 
- Faverio, M. (2023, October 18). [Key findings about Americans and data privacy](#). *Pew Research Center*. [Research Report] 
- Hargittai, E., & Marwick, A. (2016). ["What can I really do?" Explaining the privacy paradox with online apathy](#). *International Journal of Communication*, 10. [Journal article] 

Recommendations

- Related topics → Can we trust AI?

- Penn State University, [Digital Shred, Privacy Literacy Toolkit](#). Excellent resources compiled by librarians at PSU-Berks.
- [AI Pedagogy Project \(Harvard\) Assignments](#) → Filter by theme (e.g. privacy) and/or subject (e.g. ethics & philosophy)
- [Privacy-related Articles](#) from the AI Ethics & Policy News Aggregator sourced by [Casey Fiesler](#). Note: This would be an excellent place to identify recent news stories you could share with students, or incorporate into a case study.



1. Marwick, A. (n.d.). You Are Not Responsible for Your Own Online Privacy. *Wired*. Retrieved July 18, 2025, from <https://www.wired.com/story/you-are-not-responsible-for-your-own-online-privacy/>
2. Sam Altman [@sama]. (2025, April 10). *We have greatly improved memory in chatgpt—It can now reference all your past conversations! This is a surprisingly great feature imo, and it points at something we are excited about: Ai systems that get to know you over your life, and become extremely useful and personalized.* [Tweet]. Twitter. <https://x.com/sama/status/1910380643772665873>
3. Faverio, M. (2023, October 18). Key findings about Americans and data privacy. *Pew Research Center*. <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2023/10/18/key-findings-about-americans-and-data-privacy/>
4. Faverio, M.
5. Hargittai, E., & Marwick, A. (2016). "What Can I Really Do?" Explaining the Privacy Paradox with Online Apathy. *International Journal of Communication*, 10.

PHYSICAL LOCATION

The Erwin Square Mill Building
2024 West Main Street
Durham, NC 27705

MAILING ADDRESS

Box 90700
Durham, NC 27708

CONTACT US

Phone: (919) 660-5806
Email:
learninginnovation@duke.edu

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